quality variety common in the Vindhya hills on the southern edge of the Gangetic plains. Transporting the monoliths from there would have been some task, even if facilitated by the proximity of the Ganga.[28] The cylindrical blocks would have had to be rolled down hills and taken from the base areas to the river. The archaeologists P.C. Pant and Vidula Jayaswal, who first drew attention to the Chunar stone quarries, noted that five stone blocks could still be seen lying partly submerged in the river. The ancient quarries also yielded several semi-finished and unfinished cylinder blocks of stone, some of which bear letters of the Kharoshthi script. However, these are unlikely to be of Ashokan lineage since their proportions (between 1.65 to 2.25 metres in length) do not match with those of the majestic Mauryan monoliths.



Fig. 10.4: Ashokan pillar at Lumbini, with the modern Maya Devi temple by its side